

a key priority for Indian cricket administrators, given the scale of revenues generated by the IPL.

"If I was sitting in the BCCI today, with the money that we earn, I would scrap all our stadiums and build luxurious modern facilities, with amazing bathrooms, air-conditioning, escalators, glass buildings to give an unparalleled experience to the spectators," Modi said.

During his tenure, American architectural firm HKS Inc., which designed several major global sporting venues including the NFL's Lucas Oil Stadium, conducted a study of stadium infrastructure in India.

"All the stadiums were unfit to hold matches. I presented the studies to the BCCI, but nothing was done," he said.

"We talk about building a stadium for Rs 400 crore, Rs 300 crore, Rs 200 crore, but the standards are still below par compared to premium global sporting arenas," Modi said, adding: "If it was in my system, I would spend the next one year investigating where the money goes, and follow the money. It's not going to the players for sure, it's not being spent on infrastructure for sure..."

Modi believes the spectator experience remains one of the least developed aspects of the IPL ecosystem.

"Nobody cares about the fans," he said. "I was the biggest proponent of fans. Sadly, there is no proactive work at the BCCI level, or the State Association level, in looking after the fans."

Referring to last year's stampede outside the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru following Royal Challengers Bengaluru's maiden title win, Modi stressed the need for better crowd management and safety infrastructure.

"We need total fan protection, total fan experience, everything else is out of the window..."

According to him, replicating the match-day experience offered by top European football clubs could transform the relationship between fans and franchises.

"If you give him or her the



experience that he or she gets in an international venue for a Barcelona game, or a Real Madrid game, or an Arsenal game, or a Chelsea game, there will be a complete paradigm shift," he said.

Player treatment and franchise culture

In the ongoing edition of the IPL, Lucknow Super Giants owner Sanjiv Goenka attracted criticism after his alleged on-field exchange with captain Rishabh Pant went viral on social media. While such incidents have surfaced previously, Modi believes they set an unhealthy precedent for player-owner relationships.

"Sanjiv is my brother-in-law. He is married to my first cousin, my mother got him married to my first cousin, so I've grown up with that kid. I don't have any animosity with him. You don't treat players as if they're your servants or your slaves. You don't treat your employees like that. So, when I see these kinds of things happening, somebody has to have the guts to talk about it. That's why I bash him, not because of anything," Modi said.

"While football league owners treat players with respect, long-term vision, and professionalism, IPL owners are often busy chasing hype and headlines, publicly berating captains right on the boundary after tough losses," Modi added.

A creator and a disruptor

Back in 2007, when Modi first proposed a franchise-based T20 league that would blend sport and entertainment, scepticism was widespread. Nearly two decades later, the IPL has reshaped the global cricket economy and become one of the most valuable sports properties in the world. Looking back on that journey, Modi says he wants to be remembered as someone who changed the way cricket was consumed, packaged and commercialised.

"I was a disruptor, I was a creator, I was a game changer," he said with a smile.

"Now, commentators aren't allowed to take my name, nobody's allowed to, but it doesn't matter, they're immaterial to me. The fans understand it, and that's what matters to me. Nothing else does..."